1131–1167 CE), with his staunch rejection of the caste system, his emphasis on vegetarianism and his abjuring of temple worship, created a sect, the Lingayats or Veerashaivas, who are hugely influential in modern Karnataka. His challenge to caste was uncompromising. 'Loaded with the burden of the Vedas,' he said dismissively, 'the Brahmin is a veritable donkey.'[6] Though born a Brahmin himself, Basava shed his sacred thread at the age of eighteen and dismissed ideas of caste hierarchy: 'The higher type of man is the man who knows himself.' After all, as he pointed out: 'On the same earth stands the outcaste's hovel and the deity's temple. Whether for ritual or rinsing, is not the water the same?'[7] Members of all castes were the same; the Brahmin and the outcaste were born the same way. Or 'is there anybody in the world,' he asked, 'delivered through the ear?'[8]

Basava established a Hall of Experience (Anubhava Mantapa) where men and women from all castes could meet freely and discuss radical ideas. He shook off the established strictures against inter-dining and inter-marriage with 'Untouchables', provoking the social and political repression that extinguished his career; but his ideas, compiled in the form of *vachana*s, survived and have gained in strength to the present day. While the Jain influence is apparent in his establishment of monastery-like *mutths*, Basava's religious belief was in Vishishta Advaita, in which Shiva is equated with Brahman and the worship of Shiva leads to the Absolute. Another reformer, Madhvacharya (c. 1199–1294 CE), revived ideas of dualism and worship of the *saguna* Brahman in the form of Lord Krishna. His commentaries on the sacred texts, together with those of Sayana on the Vedas, are amongst the most significant contributions to Hindu philosophy after Adi Shankara's. Madhvacharya upheld dualism; in his theology the *atman* did not merge with Brahman but dwelt in close proximity to it. He also came closest to a theory of hell in Hinduism, suggesting that some souls were so weighed down by their bad deeds that they were unable to progress to salvation and had to suffer eternal damnation.

It is striking, too, that one offshoot of Bhakti contributed to the emergence of a wholly new religion, namely Sikhism. Its founder, Guru Nanak (1469–1539 CE), was also a poet and singer in the Bhakti